

Project Platypus — Where We Are & What's Next

Synthetic representatives giving non-human species an evidence-backed voice in policy · Final: Fri 24 July

1 · Open — reset what we're building (1 min)

SAY SOMETHING LIKE

"Quick reset so we're all on the same page. We're designing a framework where an AI can speak **on behalf of a species** in a real policy decision — using hard evidence, not sentiment. Think of it as giving a whale or a bee a seat at the table, backed by data. We're not behind — we just need to lock our decisions today and split the work."

2 · The core idea that makes it interesting

This is your hook — lead with it, it's what makes the project stand out.

- **One real, live policy fight.** We anchor to NOAA's current decision on whether to scrap the mandatory 10-knot ship speed limit that protects the North Atlantic right whale. It's being decided *right now* — that makes our work feel real, not hypothetical.
- **The data-rich vs data-poor contrast.** The whale has tons of data (~384 left, ~70 breeding females). Our second species (a bee or mussel) has almost none. Same pipeline, both — and the system **flags its own uncertainty** instead of faking confidence. That honesty *is* the design.
- **It speaks with confidence levels.** The output isn't "save the whale" — it's an evidence-backed position tagged HIGH / MODERATE / LOW confidence. That's what makes it credible to policymakers.

3 · What we must decide today (don't leave without these)

- 1 **Hero species** → North Atlantic right whale. Get a yes.
- 2 **Contrast species** → pick bee *or* mussel today, don't let it drift.
- 3 **Who owns what** → everyone picks a species + a workflow.
- 4 **Data rule** → all data from trusted tiers (IUCN, peer-reviewed, gov, GBIF), never AI guesswork.
- 5 **Meeting purpose** → Monday = team sync/unblock; Wednesday = report to Paul & Eddie.

4 · Suggested 7-person split (put on the table, let people choose)

Presented centrepiece

Me — Right whale + Architecture (build the pipeline)
P2 — Data-poor species (bee/mussel) + Framing

Widen the range

P4 — A moderate-data species + Data
P5 — A plant or ecosystem + Data

Framework backbone

P3 — Framing: what a "representative" is/isn't
P6 — Governance/Ethics: conflicts, anti-gaming, who audits
P7 — Economics: how it plugs into real policy

Species spread ends up: whale → moderate → plant/ecosystem → data-poor. Genuine range = proves it generalises.

5 · Ideas to make it more interesting (raise 1–2)

- **Show the whale "speaking."** Write its position as a short first-person statement to NOAA — quantified, with confidence tags. Memorable in the final.
- **Make the contrast visual.** Same slide, two species, two very different confidence profiles side by side. One image tells the whole story.
- **Tie to a real deadline.** Frame our timeline against NOAA's live decision — makes the project feel urgent and real-world.
- **A "hard problems" moment.** Openly name what's tricky — whale vs fishing industry, gaming the system. Showing we've thought about it beats pretending it's simple.

6 · Close — everyone leaves with one task

SAY SOMETHING LIKE

"So before we go — each of us claims a species and a role, and by next Monday everyone profiles their species through the pipeline. That way we walk into Wednesday with Paul and Eddie actually showing progress."

Tone reminder: you have a team lead — frame this as "I pulled together a starting point to save us time," then hand them the room. You supply structure; they keep the authority. · **Don't leave without:** 2 species chosen, 7 roles claimed, 1 task each.